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W E D N E S D A Y , A P R I L 2 3 , 2 0 2 5

MFA to return art to donor, close gallery



LANE TURNER/GLOBE STAFF/FILE

One of the bronzes in the gallery is of a Portuguese soldier, likely made in the 16th century.

Museum had sought to restore ownership of bronzes to Africa

By Malcolm Gay
GLOBE STAFF

For more than a decade, a collection of masterful works from the West African Kingdom of Benin have held pride of place at the Museum of Fine Arts, in a dedicated gallery just off the museum's central rotunda.

Now, the gallery is slated to close by the end of the month after the wealthy donor who had pledged the pieces to the museum took the ex-

traordinary step of asking for their return.

The exceedingly rare development came as the museum sought to transfer ownership of the historic works to their land of origin.

The artworks, pledged by award-winning filmmaker and banking heir Robert Owen Lehman, had long presented the museum with a daunting ethical question: Many of the sculptures were forcibly taken during a bloody raid in 1897, when

British troops sacked Benin City, plundering thousands of cast metal figures, heads, and relief plaques from the palace in what is now Nigeria.

Known collectively as the Benin Bronzes, the objects — on display in several museums in the US and Europe — are often viewed as a case study in colonial-era looting. In recent years, a number of those museums have sought to return the pil-

ARTWORK, Page A4

Rubio's plans call for huge cutbacks

Says State Department is currently 'beholden to radical political ideology'

By Edward Wong
and Michael Crowley
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — Secretary of State Marco Rubio unveiled a plan Tuesday to make major cuts to the State Department as part of a restructuring, calling the government's diplomatic agency "bloated, bureaucratic," and "beholden to radical political ideology."

Rubio released the plan in the form of an organizational chart and a brief official statement. The move is the latest by the Trump administration to reduce and reshape the government to a degree unseen in generations, which critics call a short-sightedly blunt assault on the federal bureaucracy.

The announcement Tuesday is only the first step in an overhaul of the department. It focused on changes to operations in Washington, but the cuts will affect the work of embassies and consulates overseas. Closures of diplomatic missions and layoffs abroad are expected later, according to US officials and earlier leaked memos.

The most dramatic change is the elimination of the office of the undersecretary for civilian security, democracy, and human rights, which is charged with advancing American values around the world. Trump administration officials call the office a hotbed of liberal activism.

Some elements of that office, including a bu-

STATE DEPT., Page A7

New donors send message to Harvard

Smaller gifts carry words of thanks for school's stance

By Tricia Nadolny and Joey Flechas
GLOBE STAFF

Anita Taylor, an elementary school teacher in Concord, N.H., did not attend Harvard University. And she rarely makes charitable donations.

Yet last week, after learning that the nation's oldest and wealthiest university had risked billions by rejecting a series of demands from the Trump administration, Taylor decided to open up her pocketbook.

She knew her check wouldn't make a dent in the \$2.2 billion in federal funding the administration is withholding from Harvard. But she still wanted to send a message — one more forceful than \$20 or even \$100 would convey.

She settled on giving Harvard \$1,500.

"They took a stand, and I wanted to support that in a stronger way than I would ever do," Taylor, 42, said. "I loved what the president of Harvard [said], how they explained what they were standing for. And I thought, 'Oh, thank goodness. Maybe this will build a movement.'"

In the days since the Trump administration put

HARVARD, Page A6

IN THE PINK



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Erica Paddock of Boston, whose hair competed with the blossoms, took a photo along the Charles River on the Boston side on Tuesday. With warmer temperatures, colorful blooms are more plentiful.

More than 170 higher education leaders announced they'd signed a joint statement condemning "undue government intrusion" into campus affairs. **B1.**

Pope Francis will be laid to rest Saturday after lying in state for three days in St. Peter's Basilica. **A3.**

Massachusetts is boosting the maximum period for collecting jobless benefits to 30 weeks — a move that will strain the state's unemployment trust fund, which is quickly running low on money. **B5.**

Militants opened fire on a group of tourists in the Indian-administered region of Kashmir, killing at least two dozen. **A4.**

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The outsiders

Wednesday: Sunny, nice. High: 68-73. Low: 46-51.

Thursday: More sun. High: 60-65. Low: 52-57. Sunrise: 5:51 Sunset: 7:35 Comics and Weather, **G6-7.** Obituaries, **C9.**

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'You've never had an auditor do something like this.'

MELVIN POINDEXTER, *Massachusetts Democratic National Committee member*

DiZoglio's tough take on auditor's role

Approach has fans among voters, but party has questions

By Matt Stout
GLOBE STAFF

In her crusade to scrutinize the Massachusetts Legislature, state Auditor Diana DiZoglio has fought many battles. She once rapped a one-time ally for comparing her to Donald Trump. She targeted Massachusetts House leaders, saying they tried to "defy the will of the voters." She criticized the head of her own party. She hit Senate leaders, too.

And that was just in a single week in February.

In the five months after DiZoglio

persuaded voters to give her the power to probe the Legislature, she has punched and counterpunched with increasingly velocity across Beacon Hill. She has wielded the ballot question results and sharp-tongued statements, often with fellow Democrats on the receiving end of her fusillades. Lawmakers, who've argued that the chambers have constitutional protections and that DiZoglio is politicizing her office, have lawyered up.

Practically, DiZoglio's hard-charging approach has yet to realize the audit itself. Even potential litigation over whether the Legislature has to comply sits in limbo.

Politically, however, the fight has defined her short tenure as state auditor, and elevated DiZoglio and the relatively obscure constitutional of-

fice she holds. The path she chose has led to an odd duality: She's both isolated among party leadership and simultaneously able to claim wide support among the public. Some Democratic activists view her as a rising star and natural at retail politics; others chafe at her approach, likening her to an unnecessary bomb-thrower.

In other words: DiZoglio may be the most polarizing political figure in the Massachusetts Democratic Party.

"To come out in public, take a stand and say, 'This is my mission,' it has a lot of people perplexed. This is a first. You've never had an auditor do something like this," said Melvin Poindexter, a Massachusetts Democratic National Committee member.

In contrast to DiZoglio, the role of

DIZOGLIO, Page A7

'Blair Witch' star finds herself back in the woods

Maine town divided on fate of old road

By Steve Greenlee
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

FREEDOM, Maine — An hour into a 2½-hour hike through muddy trails and ankle-deep puddles, Heather Donahue has gotten slightly off course.

"All right, well," she says, holding the leash of her 2-year-old black rescue dog, Roscoe. "I think we missed a turn back there."

For a moment, hiking seven miles through the woods of central Maine with the woman who starred in "The Blair Witch Project" doesn't seem like such a great idea. But there are no ominous piles of rocks or eerie bundles of sticks. When she finds the trail again, Donahue points out the paint marks that have gotten her into hot

water in this town of 728 people.

In 1999, Donahue starred in the most famous movie ever made about people getting lost in the woods. Twenty-six years later, she's at the center of a firestorm in rural Maine that erupted when she painted orange stripes on trees to help people find their way through the woods.

"I guess God is nothing if not humorous," she says.

Donahue, whose confessional monologue in the psychological horror film has spawned countless GIFs, moved in 2022 to the tiny town of Freedom to put fame behind her. In 2024, however, she got herself elected to the town Select Board, and a year

BLAIR WITCH, Page A10

RETRIAL UNDERWAY



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Karen Read walked into Norfolk County Superior Court in Dedham Tuesday for opening statements in her retrial. She is charged with killing Boston police officer John O'Keefe by hitting him with her SUV in 2022. Her first trial ended with no verdict. **B1.**